

What is a planet?



You think you know the answer... but what about Pluto? The truth is, that nobody knows, and not everyone agrees on what is or is not a planet.

The problem is that astronomers started spotting too many celestial bodies in the solar system that were spherical. Recent discoveries include objects such as Eris, Centaur and Makemake, all within the solar system. Objects within the asteroid belt are called “minor planets”, of which there are over 200,000. There are five “dwarf planets”, which are Ceres, Eris, Pluto, Haumea and Makemake. Bodies beyond Neptune are designated as trans-neptunian objects (or Plutoids), which are not comets. These include objects such as Varuna, Sedna, Ceto and Chaos... many of these objects also have moons. Often, these terms apply to multiple objects, Ceres is also a minor planet, and Eris is also a trans-Neptunian object. Pluto was demoted as objects such as Eris are larger and farther away than Pluto, which basically means that the solar system is much larger than commonly thought.

How to deal with tech jargon?

- Don't waste time remembering terms, they will all be out-dated by the time you actually get to use them.
- If it feels too complicated, it probably is, and will break down the first chance it gets.
- Most of the terms that consumers come across are used to sell a product. Don't be intimidated or fooled by any term.
- Replace any term that you don't understand with the word “magic” and continue.
- Stare down at the terms, and make them blink first.
- Those using the terms probably don't know exactly what they are talking about either (eg. planets).



Wear malware detection goggles

The weakest link in the security chain is often cited as humans. Social engineers try to gain access to your details using some common tricks. Be on the lookout for these easy-to-spot signatures of such tricks, and you will not be bothered by malware.

- **URL:** Whenever you enter your details, or download something, be sure to check the URL, specifically spot where the “.com” is located. For example, a url such as www.youtube.com=v12345.com/r... is actually a page hosted on com=v12345.com, and not YouTube.com. Such a site could ask you to download a plug in to view a video, and inject a malware in that plug-in.
- **Money:** This is the most common email scam. It will seem that you have suddenly received a fortune, on account of an inheritance, a lottery win, help to transfer funds of an expat – the list goes on. If you're being offered money for no apparent reason, report the mail as spam and ignore it. The odds of winning a lottery are inhuman as it is, consider the odds of winning a lottery you did not enter.
- **Pharmaceuticals:** Also perpetuated through direct mails, such mails will offer to sell you pharmaceuticals discreetly. Viagra, Cialis, anti-depressants and other such drugs are common “baits”. Responding to these e-mails is an unsafe activity on many levels. Ignore websites that offer similar services as well.
- **Porn:** Ads on web sites and emails commonly use sex-based content to lure people to pages. A video downloaded may request a particular codec, or a password from a location. Such pages are notorious for using malware. Avoid sidey sites at all cost.
- **Charity:** This kind of scam happens over phone lines as well. A cheque or a donation can be asked for in the name of a charity, but the money just disappears. If you want to donate, donate directly using known official channels.
- **Search term listing:** These sites show up high on the rankings for almost any search term, and are just a bunch of pages that link from one listing to another, without directing you to a useful place.